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and Manmohan would like to make the best use of his freedom. Is the freedom unlimited? Don't forget that the big-bang Tuesday was a victory with a price tag. Karat may have gone but the new oxygen suppliers are people like the Samajwadi Party General Secretary Amar Singh, now the most influential political deal maker in the ruling establishment, and the JMM leader Soren. There is no unconditional support in politics and Manmohan will be under pressure to return the favours. He may have won the trust vote, but can he ever win the moral war? And technically, it is still a minority government: of the 19 who saved him, 12 belong to the opposition parties. To please DMK, the Government has already brought Ram to the battleground, much to the electoral delight of the battered BJP. The Centre, in an affidavit, told the Supreme Court on July 23 that it was Lord Ram who destroyed Ram Sethu in the Palk Strait. When gods are dragged into Indian politics, the victims are always humans, but Manmohan still doesn't have the political autonomy to tell DMK's M. Karunanidhi that simple truth.

Then what about the fate of Force Manmohan within the Congress itself? A true internationalist who strives to ensure India's rightful place in the global power structure. A moderniser who risks his Government for a politically divisive but nationally enriching nuclear agenda. Like Jawaharlal Nehru, Indira Gandhi and Atal Bihari

Manmohan has always had a privileged place in middle class India. Idolised in the drawing rooms and celebrated in the marketplace, he is no longer the prisoner prime minister, at least for a while in public perception.

Politician Manmohan has been at his interactive best. He met with all allies, and spoke individually to most MPs. He not only succeeded in keeping the allies with him but ensured that no UPA MP defied the whip while NDA and other opposition parties lost 12 MPs to the ruling coalition. (Kuldeep Bishnoi of Haryana was the only rebel but he was anyway a suspended member.) The politician is at full throttle, and that means trouble.

Life as a stage-managed prime minister with no scope for political manoeuvrability must have been quite comfortable, even though occasionally humiliating. As a political prime minister who refuses to surrender, in the next few months before the general elections, he has a lot to prove—or lose. Now that the South Block is not haunted by the Marxist spectre, the first guru of liberalisation has to deliver (see box). The expectations are high

Vajpayee before him, he, too, has an idea about India, and now, he has shown the political will to stand by it. For allies like Sharad Pawar and Amar Singh Brand Manmohan is the obvious Congress candidate for the top job in the next general elections. Really? The party is not known for projecting anyone as prime minister candidate, unless the candidate has the right bloodline. Will the party let an icon flourish outside the dynasty? Manmohan may invoke the visionary leadership of Sonia Gandhi and the future hope called Rahul Gandhi, but will the First Family of Indian politics cherish the prospect of a power trinity? If the prime minister is a Congressman with a historical memory, he should know the answers. And he should be a very realistic man. The ecstasy of July 22 is neutralised by a million such hidden agonies. ■